



Scales

Most fish are covered in hundreds of scales that overlap like roof tiles. Tiny animals can get under the scales and harm them, so fish let other creatures give them a regular clean.

Mandarin fish



Colours can be used for camouflage or to attract a mate.

Colour

Fish come in all colours and patterns. Freshwater fish and those living in cooler waters tend to be duller in colour. Tropical fish are sometimes incredibly bright and beautiful.



Carp

The art of swimming

Many fish swim like snakes slide – they wriggle in an ‘s’ shape. Their whole bodies move from side to side and their tails flick to push them forwards. Their fins help to steer them.

Some fish can turn on their sides and roll right over. A few can even swim upside-down!

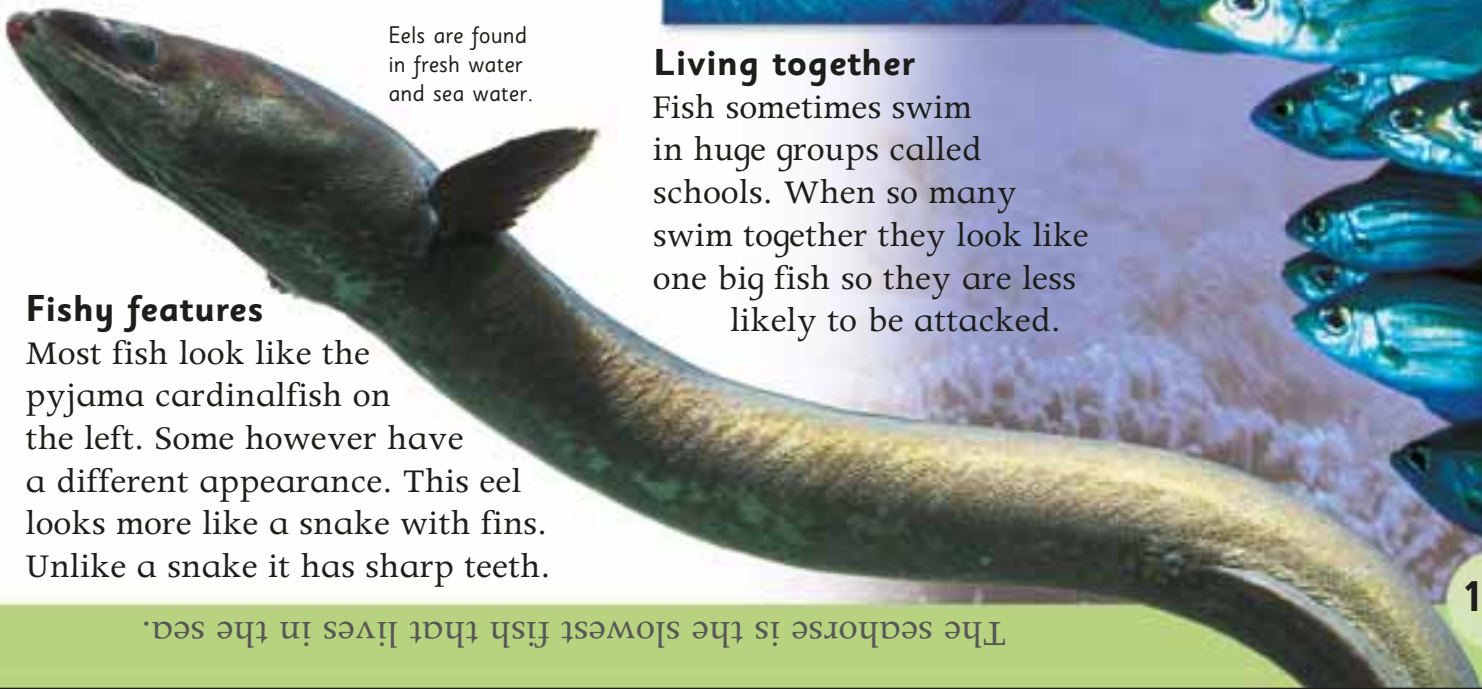


Living together

Fish sometimes swim in huge groups called schools. When so many swim together they look like one big fish so they are less likely to be attacked.

Fishy features

Most fish look like the pyjama cardinalfish on the left. Some however have a different appearance. This eel looks more like a snake with fins. Unlike a snake it has sharp teeth.



The seahorse is the slowest fish that lives in the sea.